

PYGMY RIGHT WHALE

Consisting of one species, the family Neobalaenidae is confined to waters in the southern hemisphere. Unlike true right whales, the pygmy right whale has a small, prominent dorsal fin, but no callosities on the head. Its baleen plates are ivory in colour.



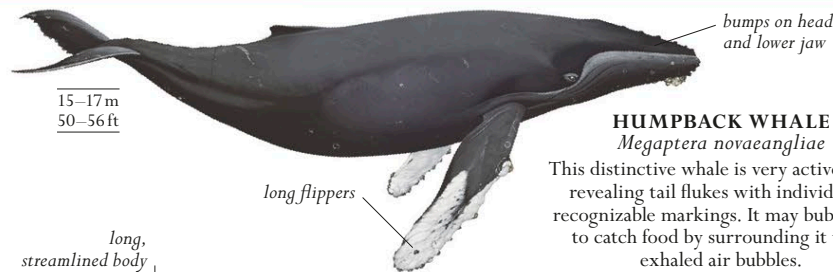
5.9–6.5 m
19–21 ft

PYGMY RIGHT WHALE

Caperea marginata
The smallest baleen whale, this species is poorly known because of its sparse population. It has short flippers and a weakly arched jaw.

RORQUALS

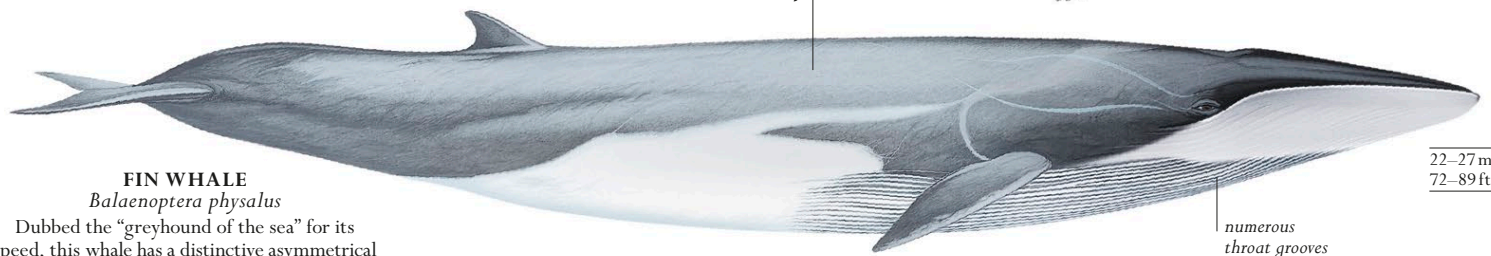
The largest family of baleen whales, rorquals are named after the Norwegian word for “furrow whale”. The furrows on their throat enable them to expand the mouth while filter-feeding. Most of the Balaenopteridae breed in temperate waters, moving to polar feeding grounds in summer. Slender and streamlined, they have long flippers and a dorsal fin set towards the rear of the body.



15–17 m
50–56 ft

HUMPBACK WHALE

Megaptera novaeangliae
This distinctive whale is very active, often revealing tail flukes with individually recognizable markings. It may bubble net to catch food by surrounding it with exhaled air bubbles.



22–27 m
72–89 ft

FIN WHALE

Balaenoptera physalus

Dubbed the “greyhound of the sea” for its speed, this whale has a distinctive asymmetrical jaw coloration. Often gregarious, it can occur in groups of up to six or more.

13–14.5 m
43–47½ ft

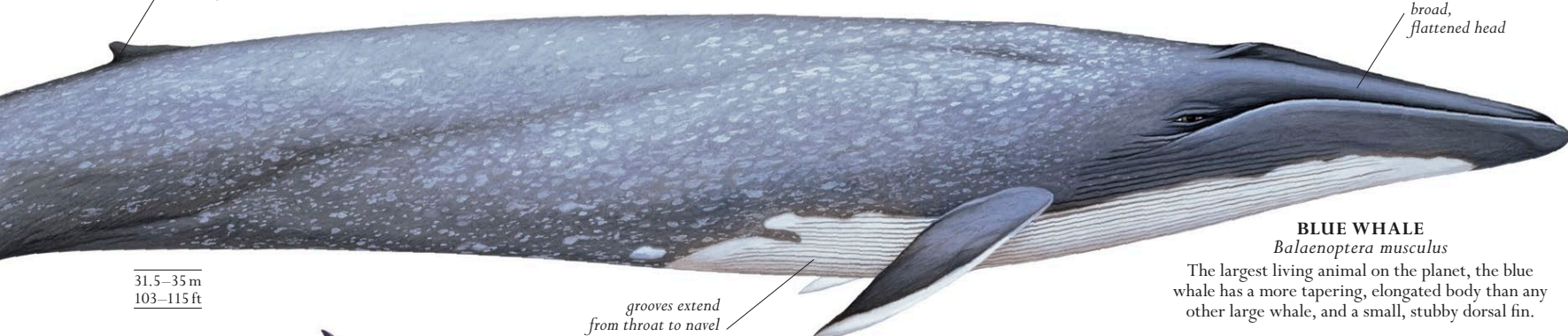
BRYDE'S WHALE

Balaenoptera edeni

Found in shallow tropical and subtropical waters around the globe, this whale is distinguished by the three ridges on its snout.



small, stubby
dorsal fin



31.5–35 m
103–115 ft

BLUE WHALE

Balaenoptera musculus

The largest living animal on the planet, the blue whale has a more tapering, elongated body than any other large whale, and a small, stubby dorsal fin.

grooves extend
from throat to navel



17–20 m
56–65 ft

SEI WHALE

Balaenoptera borealis

Mainly found in temperate waters, the sei whale is a fast-moving rorqual. Dark grey above and pale below, it has a more upright, curved dorsal fin.



6.5–8.5 m
21–27 ft

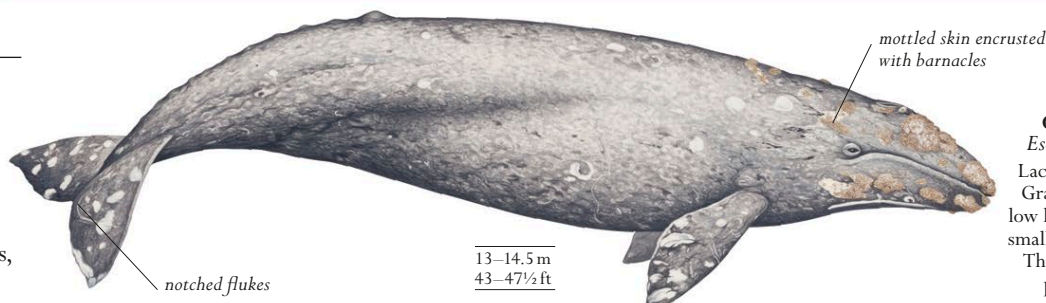
MINKE WHALE

Balaenoptera acutorostrata

The smallest rorqual, this species has a pointed snout, with a prominent ridge running from the blowhole. Its flippers usually show white patches.

GRAY WHALE

The sole species in the family Eschrichtiidae is now restricted to the eastern North Pacific, having been hunted to extinction in the Atlantic. It undertakes vast annual migrations – the longest of any mammal – from the Bering Sea to breed in subtropical waters, especially off Baja California, Mexico.



13–14.5 m
43–47½ ft

mottled skin encrusted
with barnacles

GRAY WHALE

Eschrichtius robustus

Lacking a dorsal fin, the Gray whale's back has a low hump, with a series of smaller “knuckles” behind. The throat grooves are poorly developed.